

What is requirements documentation?

Requirements documentation describes the business solution for a particular project, including the user's expectations and needs, the purpose behind that solution, and any high-level constraints that can affect successful deployment. It typically serves as the guideline for stakeholders to decide on project priorities, structure, and design to guarantee the project stays aligned with the business's overall goals. It also serves as a fundamental contract between the vendor and customer, outlining the project's deliverables and expectations. A requirement document sets the standards for determining when you have completed a project.

It allows you and the client to:

- Plan predictable project timelines so you can plan accordingly
- Define deliverables and develop only relevant functionality
- Show hidden and assumed requirements
- Get a deeper understanding of the future system or product

9 types of requirements documents

A business requirements document is a popular requirements document, but other types are also crucial to moving a project through to completion. Knowing the requirements you plan to include can help you decide which of the following requirement document types to use:

1. Functional requirements document (FRD)

An FRD defines how a project or system achieves the requirements laid out in the business requirements document. It summarizes the system's functionality by capturing its intended behaviour, expressed as services, functions, or tasks that the developers have agreed to present. Instead of defining the specifications and inner workings, an FRD concentrates on what users might notice when engaging with the system and often involves wireframes or mockups that show the system's design.

2. Market requirements document (MRD)

MRDs define the needs of a system's end-user. Business analysts, product managers, and marketing managers typically use this document. These professionals also usually determine the system's functions based on existing market trends and the target customer base's expectations. An MRD usually comprises:

- a timeframe for the product's launch
- a prioritized list of requirements from the market's perspectives
- a list of indicators of success for every requirement
- a detailed list of market requirements
- a definition of the target market

3. User interface requirements document

These documents determine the appearance of the system's graphical user interface and the positioning of user input fields, menus, messages, the footer, and the header on the application screen. The user interface requirements document explains how the user can access the screens and details their sequence for every process. These documents also typically contain mock-up screenshots to provide the project team with an idea of what the final product may look like. It shows:

- how you plan to present the content to the user
- what colours may differentiate parts of the screen
- how users can navigate the interface
- tips and hints to display on the user's screen
- shortcut keys for frequently used functions

4. Product requirements document (PRD)

A product requirements document can communicate everything you want to include in a product release before presenting it to the client. It's typically written from a user's perspective to explain what the product can do. A PRD often involves the same content as an FRD but with non-functional requirements included.

5. Business requirements document (BRD)

A BRD is the first stage in a product's life cycle. This document outlines the problems a system, service, or product may be trying to fix by listing high-level business requirements and customers' needs. It also typically summarizes the key features of the project. BRDs often include:

- project requirement outline
- project goals
- needs statement outlining the project's importance and how it plans to meet those needs
- financial statements
- functional features and requirements
- SWOT (strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats) analysis
- personnel needs
- schedules, deadlines, and timelines
- cost-benefit analysis

6. Technical requirements document (TRD)

A technical requirements document lists the platform, hardware, and software requirements of the product. It also has provisions for any programming languages needed and the processor speed required to run the system. TRDs typically have the following key elements:

- executive summary of the project
- factors, risks, and assumptions that may affect the project
- functional and non-functional requirements
- supporting documents or references

7. Software requirements document

An SRD specifies the features and the system's intended behaviour. It also outlines the business's understanding of the user's needs while describing functional and non-functional requirements. SRD relates to PRD and FRD, but it's written with a specific IT project in mind. It may have the following aspects:

- product overview
- current system summary
- proposed processes and methods
- security and design considerations

8. Quality requirements document (QRD)

A QRD describes the customer's expectations for the final product's quality. It comprises different metrics, factors and criteria. Quality requirements documents might revolve around customer experience, maintainability, usability, availability, consistency, and reliability. A business analyst or project manager can write this document.

9. Transition requirements document

Transition requirements are additional conditions and capabilities a company may need in order to transition from one business model to another. These requirements often involve staff training or data conversion. Transition requirements are always temporary, as they become unnecessary once the company has finished its transition.

The importance of documentation of requirements

Here are the main reasons documentation of requirements is important for many businesses:

Explain projects to stakeholders

Most stakeholders want to share their opinions. They also typically want to feel reassured that their business analyst has understood their desires completely. The requirements document can offer you the opportunity to show how you plan to meet their needs, preventing any unwanted surprises later in the delivery process.

Help organize priorities

Many assignments originate from an immediate business need. Preparing one project may involve consulting users, designing different processes, considering which systems to use, and preparing to meet deadlines. Having a business requirements document to work from can help you understand the most efficient way to complete these tasks by offering a clear list of goals and steps to take.

Improve client communication

Documenting requirements can allow you and the client to:

- plan predictable project timelines so you can both strategize accordingly
- define deliverables and develop only relevant functionality
- show hidden and assumed requirements
- gain a deeper understanding of the future system or product

Preserve data

It's important to have measures in place to assure the preservation of data as the project progresses and as team members change. There are many reasons team members may leave the project before it's complete. Recording your analyses as you work can help reassure the project owners that the information you've collected is still available even if you don't stay on the team.

Writing documentation of requirements for multiple teams

Some projects entail multiple teams working together, so it's important for cross-functional teams to agree on all aspects of the project. Cross-functional teams are often in a better position to quickly and efficiently solve problems than single teams. Following these tips can help you write documentation of requirements for cross-functional team projects:

Work together

IT stakeholders and businesses typically work in separate teams. It's crucial for cross-functional teams to work together to identify and prioritize requirements instead of individually analyzing the document and working independently. One practical way to do this is by making visual models depicting how users may interact with the software.

Be thorough

Each project is unique, so most can benefit from a customized approach. Writing a detailed requirements document can help make your estimate more precise and increase your chances of meeting it. Being thorough when putting together the conditions and means of their execution can help remove potential risks. This approach

offers you the chance to see potential mistakes before the development stage, which can help you save both money and time. Writing accessible requirements documents can help your entire team estimate the time they may spend implementing specific features.

Focus on people and interactions

Concentrate on iterative work instead of relying on a requirements document with every minute product detail. That encourages cross-functional collaboration, guarantees the requirements are efficient and embraces the end-users needs throughout the development stage. Collaboration provides faster, clearer outcomes, as you can accomplish this in conversation with all relevant stakeholders.

Improve customer collaboration

It's essential for organizations to collaborate with their customers if they want to create something that people value. Cross-functional teams work thoroughly with their customers to learn what concerns they are trying to resolve. Repeatedly ensuring that you and your customers agree on the details of the project can minimize the risk of misunderstanding each other.